first official act as president: I signed an executive order removing price controls on oil and gasoline, my first effort to liberate the economy from excess government regulation.

At lunch, I was able to announce that President Carter's efforts to free the fifty-two Americans held hostage for 444 days in Iran had been successful, and that the plane carrying the hostages had just crossed the border and was no longer in Iranian airspace. Jimmy Carter was already on his way home to Georgia, and my heart went out to him: I wished he had had the chance to make that announcement.

After lunch, we drove back to Pennsylvania Avenue and took our seats on a temporary grandstand that had been set up on the front lawn of the White House. From there we watched the inaugural parade. One of the bands was from Dixon High School, and for a moment or two I had a vision of the school, the main street in Dixon, Lowell Park, the lush cliffs overlooking the Rock River.

Then, with the parade over, Nancy and I headed toward the front door of the White House.

With its iron-grille fence and acres of green lawn, the big white mansion had had a mystical, almost religious aura for me since I was a child. I had first visited there when Harry Truman was president as part of a delegation of motion-picture labor leaders and then had come back when I was governor, when Lyndon Johnson and later Richard Nixon were president. But nothing had prepared me or Nancy for the emotion we felt the first time we entered the White House as its legal residents.

We walked through the front door, entering what's called the State Floor—the section of the White House that is open to public tours—and then the two of us took an elevator to the second floor, to the rooms where we would be living.

When the doors of the elevator closed behind us, we stood in a huge, long hall with a very high ceiling that extended almost the full length of the White House. On the west side